DEFENCE
DRDO

DO OR DIE FOR DRDO

Tasked to reform a faltering DRDO, the K. VijayRaghavan panel in its report has suggested comprehensive structural, operational and human resource changes. Disagreeing on several counts, a section of scientists prepare a pushback

By Pradip R. Sagar

It is no secret that the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO, the country's premier defence research agency, has been beset by systemic problems that have consistently resulted in inordinate delays and cost overruns. However, the effort to transform it, as recommended by the high-powered K. VijayRaghavan committee, has run into rough weather as a group of senior defence scientists are now opposing the contents of the report, which was submitted in January 2024.

Though the DRDO has had several significant successes—be it the development of the Agni and Pralay missiles, the Light Combat Aircraft (LCA) Tejas or the Arjun tank—the list of projects delayed is equally long—LCA Mark-II and LCA Navy aircraft, the aero-engine Kaveri and the Tapas BH-201 drone prominent among them. In February 2023, the Ministry of Defence (MoD) informed Parliament that out of 55 high-priority 'mission mode projects', 23 are behind schedule. It was felt that the organisation, which operates nearly 50 laboratories and has a staff strength of around 30,000, had lost focus on defence research, over-extended itself into other areas



ENGINE ROOM
Prime Minister Narendra Modi at the launch of DRDO young scientists' labs in Bengaluru

CHANGES IN COMM

CURRENT

MINISTRY OF DEFENCE

DRDO chairman & secretary, Dept of R&D, MoD

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Huge project delays and cost overruns: 23 out of 55 high-priority 'mission mode' projects like cruise missiles, torpedos decoy systems, nuclear defence technology are behind schedule. Main reason: involvement in other areas, too many projects